Run the prototype

FACILITATOR ONLY | SETUP AND CLOCK

Version 0.1 | Five players + you | 60 minutes. This pack contains all hidden consequences. Keep it away from players. The player pack can be distributed openly, though shared faction briefs need only go to their faction.

Before the session

Print the player pack once, single-sided A4 at 100%. Print this facilitator pack once. Cut player pp. 6-10 and the four visions on facilitator p. 5. Use coins for tokens, or print an extra copy of player p. 12 to cut its tokens while keeping the board intact. Bring pens, three track counters and a clock or ordinary watch. No electronic game system is needed.

Place the two council references at separate nearby tables. Keep public guide pp. 1-2 and board p. 12 between them. Give briefs p. 3 to the Guild, p. 4 to the Janissariat and p. 5 plus worksheet p. 11 to the Ascendant. Hold round-two decisions, Charter cards and settlement sheet until their scheduled use. Give all six Charter cards out at the start of round-one councils.

Set Route, Communities and Army to 2. Give the Guild 3 Navigator tokens, the Janissariat 3 Force, and the Ascendant 1 Reserve. Assign one delegate from each faction to each council; seats stay fixed. The Ascendant sits on Security. Each faction meets together during its faction phases; the Ascendant meets you.

Clock	Your task
00-08	Read the premise; explain seats, commitments, authority and unknown consequences. Show the round-one council cards. Explain that shared faction goals replace individual goals.
08-13	Round-one faction phase. Deal only the chosen R1 vision. Lock faction commitments and the reserve slip at 13.
13-20	Councils. Give out six Charter cards. At 20 lock both orders and separate article proposals.
20-26	Resolve and announce within about 2 minutes. Post provisional articles for round two. Players negotiate during the remaining time.
26-31	Round-two faction phase. Refresh capacity, accounting for navigator loss. Show R2 council cards; deal only the chosen R2 vision. Lock at 31.
31-38	Councils under the posted articles. No operational amendments. Lock at 38.
38-44	Resolve and announce. Players use remaining time to negotiate the settlement.
44-54	Ceremony. Give the settlement sheet to the group. Warn at 52. Verify signatures and stop at 54.
54-60	Read the ending and run the short debrief on player p. 13.

Foresight handling

Offer a choice of this round's Navigation or Security vision. No choice by the faction bell means no vision that round. Do not describe the unseen branch. The selected card may stay with the Ascendant. Clarify terms without suggesting choices or reporting player plans. All four visions are fixed consequences, including those never inspected.

Resolve a round

FACILITATOR ONLY | FOLLOW IN ORDER

1. Record the opening state

Before the faction phase note the three track values, Guild capacity and current articles. Round-two visions use **opening Route**, before any maintenance or other effects. Interim rules govern all of round one; valid round-one proposals govern all of round two.

2. Check commitments and legal orders

Use Maintenance / Partial rest for missing or unsigned faction cards. Correct pool sizes to the printed choice. Navigator capacity is 3, or 2 after the R1 loss. Force capacity is always 3. No later additions or transfers are legal.

Check the council card against current authority. Interim/N-I: Ascendant chooses Navigation; N-G: Guild; N-J: both delegates. Interim/M-I: Ascendant chooses Security; M-A: Janissariat; M-J: both delegates. Ignore advice from a non-authority. Missing, ambiguous, unauthorised or forbidden orders default to Close/Rest without an unfunded penalty. Requisition is forbidden under M-J.

3. Bridge, pay and default

Costs: Convoy 2 Navigators, Repair 2, Close 0; Escort 2 Force or 1 under M-J, Requisition 3, Rest 0. A lodged Bridge triggers only for the named legal paid order if its committed pool is short by exactly 1. Spend Reserve and add the one capacity. Then check both councils independently.

Run each fully funded order and spend its cost. Any remaining unaffordable paid order becomes Close/Rest, spends zero, and gives Communities -1. Record one such penalty per failed paid order. A fallback Rest uses the current Military article's Rest benefit. Do not partly execute an order.

4. Establish protection

A **military Escort** means Security's final funded order is Escort, including one funded by Bridge Security. **Protected convoy** means final funded Convoy plus either a military Escort or triggered Insurance. Insurance triggers only for a funded Convoy without a military Escort. It spends Reserve then, even if the vision hazard was not present.

Insurance does not create an Escort order and earns no military-Escort bonus. If the lodged reserve did not trigger, return it and cancel the intervention at round end. A spent reserve never returns.

5. Add all effects, then limit tracks

Add faction effects (p. 3), final council effects (p. 3), unfunded penalties, Charter bonuses and every applicable hidden consequence (p. 4). Use opening Route for R2 conditions. Apply R2 cargo loss by replacing the convoy's cargo benefits with zero; other convoy effects remain. At the end only, limit Route, Communities and Army individually to 0-4.

Mark a navigator lost if triggered in R1. This is a permanent recorded loss and reduces next round's Guild capacity from 3 to 2. No other rule removes capacity. No player is eliminated at 0.

6. Announce and update authority

Announce final orders, funded costs, reserve use, changed tracks and triggered hidden consequences. Explain what caused each result. Return the order cards. After R1 resolution, post each valid article proposal for R2; an absent, multiple or incompletely signed proposal leaves that category interim. Require both delegates and the Ascendant, even where the operational order had a single decision-maker.

Changing an article cannot retrospectively change this round's orders. After R2, all articles stay provisional until the Ceremony. Do not permit new actions in free discussion.

Ordinary consequences

FACILITATOR ONLY | COMPLETE PUBLIC RULES TABLE

Notation: **R** = Route, **C** = Communities, **A** = Army. Add rows as deltas. A dash means no change. All effects apply even if another track would reach zero; limit values only once at round end.

Faction choice	Committed pool	Track delta
Guild Full service	All available: 3 or 2	-
Guild Maintenance	Available minus 2: 1 or 0	R +1
Guild Withdraw	0	R +2; C -1
Janissariat Mobilise	3 Force	-
Janissariat Partial rest	1 Force	A +1
Janissariat Recall	0	A +2; C -1

Final funded Navigation	Cost	Track delta
Convoy: interim/N-J, round 1	2 Nav	C +1; A +1
Convoy: interim/N-J, round 2	2 Nav	C +2; A +1
Convoy: N-G	2 Nav	C +2; A +0
Convoy: N-I	2 Nav	C +0; A +2
Any Convoy, not protected	Already paid	R -1, in addition to cargo
Repair, either round	2 Nav	R +2; C -1; A -1
Close, round 1	0	R +1; C -1; A -1
Close, round 2	0	R +1; C -2; A -2

Final funded Security	Cost	Track delta
Escort: interim/M-I/M-A	2 Force	No direct change; convoy protection
Escort: M-J	1 Force	Same protection
Requisition: interim/M-I/M-A	3 Force	A +2; C -1
Requisition: M-J	Forbidden	Invalid; use Rest
Rest: interim/M-I/M-J	0	A +1; C -1
Rest: M-A	0	A +2; C -1
M-I + military Escort + Convoy	No extra cost	A +1 in addition

Failure or protection	Exact treatment
Unfunded paid order	Default to Close/Rest and add C -1 per failed order; spend no capacity on that order.
Invalid or absent order	Default to Close/Rest; no C penalty for invalidity alone.
Escort without Convoy	Pay Escort cost; no ordinary direct benefit. R1 Repair bonus can still apply (p. 4).
Insurance protection	Prevent Convoy R -1 and unescorted-convoy hazards only. No military-Escort bonus.
Unused committed capacity	No benefit or penalty. Refresh next round; do not bank it.

Interim is not an article: it uses balanced cargo, normal costs and no M-I or M-A bonus. A final ratified Charter cannot select Interim; it must select a printed article in each category.

Hidden consequences and endings

FACILITATOR ONLY | APPLY WHETHER OR NOT THE VISION WAS SEEN

Round one - test final funded orders

Condition	Additional result
Convoy without protection	A navigator is lost. Mark the loss; Guild capacity becomes 2 in R2. No additional track loss beyond ordinary Convoy R -1.
Repair + military Escort	Escorts secure the maintenance teams: R +1 in addition to Repair.
Requisition + Guild Withdraw	Unprotected depots erupt in resistance: C -1 in addition.
Convoy + military Escort	The escorted delivery earns confidence: C +1 in addition. Insurance alone does not qualify.

Round two - opening Route is fixed before faction choices

Condition	Additional result
Convoy; opening Route 0 or 1; no protection	Cargo is lost. Replace all Navigation cargo benefits with zero, under any N article. Retain ordinary Route loss. No further Navigator loss.
Repair; opening Route 3 or 4	Reliable local feeder routes keep food moving: C +1 in addition.
Requisition under M-A	Military requisition under autonomous authority sparks resistance: C -1 in addition.
Rest under M-J	The joint council's failure to act undermines the troops: A -1 in addition, cancelling the ordinary Rest A +1. Faction rest effects still apply.

These are the **only** hidden effects. They do not change who may decide or create extra costs. Multiple applicable rows stack. R1 and R2 effects apply only in their named round. A fallback order counts as the final order for all conditions.

Ceremony and ending

There is one settlement sheet. Exactly one N article and one M article must be circled. Both members initial for each faction and the Ascendant signs. If the package changes, obtain all approvals again. At 54 minutes, verify the latest row against the current package. No complete approval means no ratification. Side promises do not substitute for signatures.

Ratified: read the selected article titles and state who now decides each domain. **Not ratified:** announce that the provisional arrangements expired and interim authority returned. In either case, describe each track using the table below. Do not apply article effects again at signature.

Final value	Route	Communities	Army
0-1	Corridor unreliable; empire remains divided.	Shortages and anger dominate the settlements.	Stranded force is exhausted and close to breakdown.
2	Corridor usable but fragile.	Basic needs met; confidence remains thin.	Force can hold together, but needs recovery.
3-4	Corridor dependable.	Settlements supplied and broadly cooperative.	Force supplied and ready for its next purpose.

If a navigator was lost, state it separately; a good final Route does not undo that death. Invite each faction to assess its shared priorities. There is no universal points total or declared overall winner.

The possible futures

CUT INTO FOUR | GIVE ONLY ONE MATCHING CARD PER ROUND

V1-N | Round one: Navigation

You see an empty navigator's chair. In another passage, soldiers guard workers repairing the corridor.

If the final funded order is Convoy without a military Escort or Reserve Insurance: a navigator is lost. Your Guild will have only 2 Navigator capacity next round, rather than 3. Ordinary convoy Route loss still applies.

If the final funded orders are Repair and military Escort: Route gains an additional +1.

These are conditional futures, not predictions of player choices. Insurance can prevent the loss but cannot earn the repair bonus. Both consequences are checked whether or not you tell anyone.

V1-S | Round one: Security

You see sealed depots and an angry crowd. Elsewhere, an escorted convoy arrives to a public welcome.

If the final funded Security order is Requisition and the Guild chose Withdraw: Communities suffers an additional -1.

If the final funded orders are Convoy and military Escort: Communities gains an additional +1.

Reserve Insurance is protection, not a military Escort, and does not earn this bonus. Changing the printed conditions averts that future; there is no extra penalty for doing so.

V2-N | Round two: Navigation

You see cargo tumbling into the dark. Another vision shows old feeder routes opening while the main corridor is repaired.

If opening Route is 0 or 1, and the final funded Convoy has neither military Escort nor Reserve Insurance: lose all convoy cargo benefits. Keep its ordinary Route loss. This causes no new Navigator loss.

If opening Route is 3 or 4 and the final funded order is Repair: Communities gains an additional +1.

Opening Route is the value before this round's faction choices. Maintenance this round does not change that test.

V2-S | Round two: Security

You see a commander taking supplies in their own name. Elsewhere, soldiers wait for a joint council that cannot decide.

If the final funded Security order is Requisition under M-A military autonomy: Communities suffers an additional -1.

If the final Security order is Rest under M-J joint authorisation: Army suffers an additional -1, cancelling the order's usual +1. Faction rest bonuses still apply.

The second condition includes default Rest after a deadlock, invalid order or failed funding. The additional unfunded-order Communities penalty still applies when relevant.

Walkthroughs and playtest record

FACILITATOR ONLY | DESK-CHECKED, NOT YET GROUP-PLAYTESTED

The following cases use the same resolution rules as this pack. Values are end-of-round Route / Communities / Army. They are examples, not recommended player strategies.

Case	Choices and result
Cooperation and a bargain	R1: Full service, Mobilise, Repair, Escort, no reserve -> 4 / 1 / 1. Enact N-J + M-I. R2: Full service, Mobilise, Convoy, Escort -> 4 / 3 / 3. The mixed settlement meets all survival thresholds.
Withheld assets	R1: Withdraw, Recall; Ascendant orders Convoy and Escort; no reserve. Both fail into Close/Rest, with two unfunded penalties -> 4 / 0 / 4. Troops recover while communities suffer.
Averted prophecy	R1: Full service, Partial rest, Convoy, Rest; Insurance lodged -> 2 / 2 / 4, no navigator lost, reserve spent. Without Insurance -> 1 / 2 / 4 and a navigator lost.
Bridge a commitment	R1: Maintenance, Mobilise, Convoy, Escort; Bridge Navigation -> 3 / 4 / 3, reserve spent. With no bridge the convoy fails into Close -> 4 / 0 / 1.
Conflicting authority	R2 under N-G: Guild initials Repair; Ascendant sends a Convoy directive. Repair is lawful. If the card instead contains only the Ascendant's Convoy instruction, default to Close without an unfunded penalty. Under N-J, two delegates choosing different orders also default to Close.
Failed ratification	Finish the cooperative example but omit either faction's approval at the Ceremony. Provisional N-J/M-I expire; interim authority returns. Tracks remain 4 / 3 / 3.

Mechanical checks

The accompanying desk check exhaustively resolved **103,680** single-round combinations across both rounds, all authority pairs, legal order choices, commitments, opening Route values, Navigator capacities and reserve selections. It checked track bounds, funding, protected convoys, reserve use and both complete two-round examples. Authority and ratification edge cases were checked separately. No failed checks were found.

This confirms rule consistency, not balance, reading time or enjoyment. The five-player group test remains to be run. Seven minutes of council work includes article negotiation in R1; note whether this feels rushed.

Record immediately after play

Date / players: _____
Finished within 60 minutes? ____ Longest delay: _____
Both members contributed in each faction? _____
Did a vision alter a decision, intervention or bargain? _____
Did experience change a preferred Charter article? _____
Any instruction requiring an invented ruling? _____
One change for the next test: _____

Design sources: The Void Throne working drafts and Charter of Settlement supplied by John Keyworth; the supplied Shot Heard Around the Universe constitution cards; decid:r decision-loop and facilitator examples. This is a new paper prototype, not a reproduction of those games' full rules.